

Submission on Implementing Carpentry Registration and Licensing

Response to the Victorian Department of Transport and Planning consultation paper

Consultation submission version 0.4 Review 7

Prepared by Carpenters for Housing Reform Victoria

Submitted by Dan Sonsie, founder and evidence custodian

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Evidence review status: Original v0.3 audit controls retained. This candidate incorporates Dan's approved directions, departmental correspondence and targeted primary-source checks. Historical evidence is separately attributed. Unsettled carpenter-scheme scope, assessment, insurance and commencement settings are treated as matters for consultation, not adopted law. Independent legal, policy, economic and practitioner review has not been completed.

Submission status: Prepared for Dan's final approval. Not submitted.

Closing date: Sunday 11 October 2026.

This submission supports proportionate competence and accountability requirements where evidence establishes material risk, a limitation in existing controls and an incremental public benefit. It distinguishes minimum trade competence from advanced residential capability and preserves evidence-based career progression. The choice of regulatory mechanism should follow the function, evidence and implementation test.

I am Dan Sonsie, founder of Carpenters for Housing Reform Victoria and a practising carpenter with approximately 20 years' experience. This submission draws on my firsthand carpentry experience and longstanding informal discussions with industry colleagues; it does not claim their formal endorsement or to represent every Victorian carpenter.

Executive position

Carpenters for Housing Reform Victoria conditionally supports minimum competence and accountability requirements for regulated carpentry work. The scope should be justified by attributable risk, the limitations of existing controls, the likely incremental benefit and the cost to workers, businesses and consumers. A simpler or narrower intervention should be preferred where it achieves the required outcome.

One leading option for detailed testing is a work-and-risk-based framework rather than wholesale duplication of Victoria's legacy domestic and commercial builder classes. Technical competence should be defined by the work a practitioner is authorised to perform. Contracting authority, business competence, financial requirements and insurance should be attached where justified by the practitioner's functions, authority and risk. Legislative feasibility and insurance consequences should be tested before the model is settled.

The scheme should establish a credible minimum carpenter standard without assuming that entry registration demonstrates every capability required in complex residential renovation. This initiative proposes Registered Residential Carpenter (RRC) as a candidate for a bounded advanced-capability pilot. The pilot should test the need and benefit before wider rollout. An endorsement, revised existing class, additional class, non-statutory credential or no additional mechanism remain alternatives; the final statutory vehicle is not predetermined.

The 2024 draft impact analysis is used only as historical context. Its figures do not represent current government policy or a current forecast and should not determine the final design without updated evidence.

Primary recommendations

- Test a residential carpenter baseline before additional recognition layers. Compare a clear work-and-risk-based residential scope with alignment to relevant existing domestic builder classes and any justified specialist requirements. Publish the scope, evidence and burden comparison before selecting the regulatory mechanism.
- Apply a common technical competence standard to employees and subcontractors performing the same prescribed residential work. Add separate role requirements for relevant business, contracting, probity, financial and insurance responsibilities where justified by functions, authority and risk.
- Use mandatory building standards and consequence of failure as the starting point for prescribed work, while addressing temporary stability, interfaces between trades, progressive discovery and other risks not captured by a simple list of finished work types.
- Preserve a lawful continued-work pathway for the existing workforce, with verified competence, targeted gap training and controls matched to identified gaps. Model staged commencement and provisional recognition against alternatives before setting duration and conditions.
- For future entrants, use completed carpentry apprenticeship and Certificate III evidence to establish baseline technical competence. For existing workers, recognise reliably verified equivalent competence and address identified gaps. Avoid duplicate whole-of-trade testing where reliable outcomes are already demonstrated; justify any additional licensing assessment by its specific purpose.
- Retain registered-builder accountability and define the interaction between builders, subcontractors, employees, apprentices, owner-builders and corporate entities in plain operational guidance.
- Collect baseline and post-implementation data capable of testing whether registration reduces attributable defects rather than merely increasing the number of regulated practitioners.
- Recommend independent operational testing of assessment and transition processes before full commencement, including regional access, processing time, cost and assessor calibration. This recommendation does not activate the initiative's pilot or instruments.

What the consultation changes

Issue	Current consultation signal	Submission implication
Class structure	DTP is testing legacy builder-class alignment against work-and-risk-based classes.	Test a clear residential baseline against relevant domestic builder classes, with scope and authority boundaries.
Role tiers	DTP questions whether separate subcontractor registration and employee licensing remain proportionate.	Use the same technical competence standard for the same residential work, with separate role requirements matched to responsibilities and authority.
Existing workforce	Provisional pathways, recognition of competence and targeted gap training are open for design.	Offer an evidence-governed transition model, not automatic grandfathering or forced repetition.
Advanced capability	The paper focuses on minimum competence and direct accountability.	Explain that advanced renovation capability is a separate progression question and should not be inferred from basic registration.
Future regulation	The framework may extend to waterproofing and welding.	Use a coherent architecture that can scale across trades without copying unsuitable legacy classes.
Consultation slides	Slides 2 and 5 identify four objectives and proportionality; slide 3 describes proposed role permissions; slide 6 addresses transition and operational readiness.	Map each recommendation to an objective and risk. Proposed permissions are not a statement that new requirements have commenced. [6]
Stakeholder views	The 6 October email reports support and opposition. Supporters expected workforce and quality benefits; opponents questioned the evidence, further regulatory change and worker acceptance.	Retain both views. No participation proportions or causal results are supplied. [7]
Transition and retirement	The email reports calls for staging and suitable arrangements for older carpenters approaching retirement.	Model accessible pathways and process relief while retaining competence outcomes; no fixed duration or age waiver is established. [7]

DTP's slides describe proposals and intended outcomes. Its 6 October email reports both support and opposition and says views will inform advice to the incoming Government. Courtney Gleeson's subsequent reply identifies current contract rules, separate proposed contract reforms and historical RIS sections for further reading. These sources do not announce a final carpenter model or endorse this initiative. The historical RIS disclaimer remains applicable. [2; 6–7; 9–12]

Response to consultation questions

Question 1 Priority objectives and outcomes

The four stated government objectives are improved consumer confidence, fewer building defects, incentives for skills formation and qualifications, and greater regulatory oversight. Recommendations should show how they contribute to these objectives. Recruitment, retention and work-quality improvements reported by supporters are expectations to test, not measured results. Workforce capacity and clear practitioner scope should be monitored alongside consumer outcomes. [6, slides 2 and 5; 7]

- Where current data permits, measure defect incidence and severity by work type and responsible role, not only total complaints. Where it does not, develop and publish a transparent attribution method.
- Establish baseline measures for workforce participation, apprentice completion, illegal work, application delays and regional access using available data, while identifying material gaps and estimation limits.
- Publish clear scope and disciplinary history so registration conveys useful information rather than a generic badge.

Question 2 Effectiveness of registration and licensing

The proposed causal chain is that verified competence and practitioner traceability enable more effective compliance and enforcement, which may reduce attributable defects and improve accountability. Each link needs evidence. Registration alone cannot establish the result: defects may arise from design, materials, sequencing, supervision, commercial pressure or decisions made by others. The causal responsibilities of carpenters and registered builders must remain distinct and visible. [6, slide 2; 7]

- Pair entry controls with active compliance, technical guidance, rectification and proportionate enforcement.
- Do not assume that a qualification or registration alone establishes competence in every work context.
- Evaluate outcomes against a pre-implementation baseline and adjust the scheme where expected benefits are not demonstrated.

Question 3 Alternative regulatory approaches

Compare individual entry controls with contractor accountability, stronger builder supervision, targeted inspections, records for concealed or critical work, technical education and voluntary advanced recognition. A contractor-focused alternative was raised in the structured meeting record; it is a stakeholder option, not selected government policy. The correct approach is the lowest intervention that demonstrably addresses the verified problem, including no additional restriction where existing or less burdensome controls suffice. [5, DTPM-026 and 032]

- Use registration only where a verified material risk and incremental accountability benefit justify entry restrictions.
- Use guidance, education or voluntary recognition where restriction is not justified.
- Use targeted inspection and evidence requirements where defects are not reliably prevented by entry qualifications.

Question 4 Risk factors for restricting work

Risk should be assessed by consequence of failure, mandatory standards, concealed conditions and the independent judgment exercised. Ordinary repairs should remain practicable within a carpenter's demonstrated competence and lawful authority. Discovering rot does not automatically require specialist referral. The reason for additional input should be specific, such as work outside lawful scope, an unresolved safety or design issue, or a required specialist approval. Contract value can affect contracting requirements but should not alone define technical competence or permit obligations.

Keep administration proportionate for routine, low-value jobs. Do not impose major domestic building contract documentation solely because a carpenter is registered where applicable law does not require it; retain other applicable consumer, permit and insurance obligations. Regulation 6 fixes the major-contract threshold at \$10,000; sections 3 and 29 address the threshold and appropriately authorised registration. Separate draft contract regulations propose \$20,000. The departmental reply reports expected commencement on 31 March 2027; that is not carpenter-scheme commencement or proof the threshold has changed. Reassess scope and contracting arrangements when discoveries expand a job. No new carpenter contract-value cap is proposed here. [9–12] Contract requirements and insurance thresholds are separate. BPC guidance describes Home Warranty for eligible domestic building work over \$20,000 under the new arrangements from 1 July 2026, with eligibility, exclusions and transitional treatment to be checked. This does not establish future carpenter insurance settings or a general exemption from other duties. [17]

Proposed scope should be tested across residential outdoor carpentry as well as work inside homes: decks, verandahs, fences, gates and appropriate shed carpentry. These examples require work-specific mapping; they are not blanket permissions for whole structures, retaining walls or other regulated activities. Select replacement timber using the applicable dimensions, strength grade, durability or treatment, spans, loads and connections. An imperial description or larger member alone does not establish equivalent performance. Building-permit requirements and barrier requirements are separate: a deck below one metre is not automatically permit-exempt. Follow applicable planning approvals, building permits, approved design and specialist responsibilities. [13–14]

- Structural stability and load path, including temporary stability during alteration.
- Weatherproofing, cladding, wet-area and building-envelope interfaces.
- Fire safety, safe access and egress, accessibility and energy-performance obligations.
- Work concealed before ordinary inspection and work dependent on another practitioner's design or certification.
- Existing-building uncertainty and progressive discovery: make unsafe areas safe, explain changed conditions to the owner, reassess the affected scope and pause affected work where safety, authority or required approvals remain unresolved. Continue work within established competence and lawful scope; obtain other practitioner input when a specific boundary requires it.

Question 5 Existing builder classes or proposed risk-based classes

Our proposed baseline registration is limited to residential carpentry, covering defined carpentry work in new homes and existing homes. It establishes competence to perform that work and does not, by implication, grant consumer contracting, project-level supervision or builder authority. Compare a clear work-and-risk-based residential scope with relevant existing domestic builder classes before selecting the statutory mechanism. Apply specialist requirements only where the authorised work and evidence justify them.

Residential scope is the initiative's recommendation, not a claim that government has adopted a residential-only scheme. The Department may need separate arrangements for non-residential work. Publish boundaries for mixed-use buildings, ancillary structures and temporary works so practitioners can identify when another class or responsible practitioner is required. This proposal does not confer authority outside the defined residential scope.

- Map the proposed residential scope against existing domestic builder classes and clarify interfaces with non-residential work to prevent gaps, overlap or authority by implication.
- Retain builder classes for broader contracting, supervision and project responsibility.
- Review whether omitted activities such as stairs, temporary support and fire-related carpentry create material gaps rather than excluding them solely because other occupations also perform them.

Question 6 Subcontractor and employee tiers

Employees and subcontractors performing the same prescribed residential carpentry work should meet the same technical competence standard. For employees working under a builder, completed apprenticeship and Certificate III evidence should normally establish the baseline technical outcome, subject to any lawful registration conditions. Independent business operation calls for additional relevant business and contracting requirements; it does not automatically establish advanced technical capability or authority to contract for every project. Requirements should follow responsibilities, authority and risk, rather than imposing unrelated business or financial obligations on employees. [6, slide 3]

- Use terminology consistently across building and plumbing frameworks.
- Make movement between employee and subcontractor roles administratively simple. Retain verified technical competence and assess only additional role requirements; an unchanged work scope should not require repeat technical assessment solely because employment status changes.
- Retain the responsible registered builder's project-level accountability while making each carpenter's responsibility for their own work and boundary decisions clear. Separate role requirements do not transfer builder authority or responsibility to a carpenter.

Authority and handoff boundaries. Distinguish baseline permission to perform prescribed work, requirements for independent business operation, and any additional assessed authority for defined residential work. Technical registration does not itself confer unrestricted consumer contracting, project supervision, structural design or certification, or specialist-trade authority. Consider a bounded progression route for experienced carpenters where evidence supports it, while retaining builders', engineers', building surveyors' and licensed trades' responsibilities. Extra labour or a larger budget does not resolve an authority or design boundary.

Optional modules could be tested for defined existing-building renovation, outdoor structures, or other specified work, including retaining-wall tasks only where competence, design and approval boundaries are established. Assess the function, consumer benefit, business obligations and insurance before granting additional authority. RRC, an endorsement or a revised existing class remain possible mechanisms; none is predetermined. Any future financial limit needs separate justification. No new monetary cap is selected or proposed in this submission.

Slide 3 summarises proposed builder, subcontractor and employee permissions, but does not show a below-threshold contracting column. Courtney Gleeson directs us to historical RIS sections 1.3 and 1.3.2 and Table 0.1. The table shows subcontractors contracting for carpentry under \$10,000 under the then-existing scheme, with new registration and disciplinary obligations proposed separately. This helps explain the meeting statement rather than establishing a contradiction with the slides. Current law and proposed changes must be checked separately; permits, insurance, corporate roles and carpentry commencement remain distinct questions. [2, pp. 28–31; 5, DTPM-015–019; 6, slide 3; 9]

Question 7 Provisional pathways

A lawful continued-work pathway should be available for the existing workforce while identified gaps are addressed. Provisional registration is a credible mechanism, but an alternative may be preferable if it provides equivalent continuity, assessment integrity and accountability. Entry must still require identity, verified work-history and baseline safety evidence. Transitional status should not become automatic grandfathering.

For future entrants, this initiative recommends a completed carpentry apprenticeship with Certificate III as the normal baseline technical foundation. Recognise those assessed outcomes rather than routinely repeating a full trade test. If an additional licensing module or examination is proposed, specify the regulatory knowledge or competence gap it addresses and demonstrate its necessity. No compulsory additional exam or wholesale Certificate III redesign is selected here. Consider existing-building awareness in training only after mapping current coverage and any demonstrated gaps. [6, slide 4; 8]

- Assess competence against the required outcome; qualifications and references are evidence, not substitutes for reliable verification where gaps remain.

For existing workers, missing apprenticeship records should not by itself exclude a competent applicant.

Use verified work history, representative work evidence, corroborating references and practical assessment appropriate to the gaps. Require targeted training or experience where competence is not demonstrated; do not rely on tenure alone or make competent workers repeat a full qualification unnecessarily. The historical RIS describes transition assessment and training plans, but does not establish current adopted settings. [2, pp. 71–72; 9]

- Recognise prior learning and verified experience.
- Require only targeted training or experience for demonstrated gaps.
- Apply conditions proportionate to the specific gap and provide a defined route to full registration.

Set transition duration using cohort size, verified gaps, safety risk and regulator and training capacity. A five-year pathway was raised by a meeting participant and appears in the historical RIS with an application window and training-plan conditions. Neither source establishes a current adopted duration. Avoid indefinite provisional status or unsupervised work where safety-critical competence remains unproven. [2, pp. 71–72; 5, DTPM-022 and 033; 7; 9]

Recognition of prior learning should retain the rigour needed to establish the required competence. Some providers advertise approximately three months for recognition of skills already acquired, not three months of novice trade training. Duration alone does not establish invalid assessment. Require authentic, current and sufficient evidence, reliable practical verification where needed, and targeted gap training. ASQA warns against inadequate assessment and misleading RPL marketing. Preserve legitimate recognition for experienced workers while addressing demonstrated assessment failures. [15–16]

Question 8 Oversight of provisional practitioners

Oversight should be risk- and gap-based. A person with a narrow documentary gap should not face the same controls as a person with an unresolved safety-critical competence gap. Oversight may involve an appropriately registered builder, a registered practitioner in the relevant class, an approved assessor or the BPC, depending on the function.

Documentary screening should distinguish missing records from an actual competence gap. Specify who verifies each gap and who may impose or review conditions; proposed assessor involvement should not imply statutory powers that have not been established.

- Record the identified gap, permitted work, supervision or verification requirement, milestones and completion evidence.
- Do not permit unsupervised performance where a safety-critical capability remains unproven.
- Use independent moderation for contested assessments and critical-failure decisions.

Question 9 Support for experienced carpenters

Government should minimise avoidable cost and time away from work while preserving the competence outcome. Options should include targeted subsidies or capped transition-assessment costs, regional and after-hours access, plain-language guidance, pre-application checking and recognition of verified workplace evidence. Eligibility and funding levels should follow current cost and workforce modelling.

- Test targeted funding or capped assessment costs against eligibility, workforce need and a current cost model; the announced \$16 million program is not an allocation to these proposals. [6, slide 2; 20]
- Develop a competent assessor workforce before applications open.
- Accept reliable workplace evidence through methods compatible with the BPC's published assessment process; avoid duplicating verification already completed.
- Provide additional navigation support for small businesses, older practitioners and people with limited digital confidence.

Question 10 Alternatives to provisional registration

Staged commencement, cohort-based application windows and streamlined recognition may reduce disruption. Whatever statutory mechanism is selected should preserve lawful continued work for timely applicants and a verified route to full registration. An experienced-practitioner route could grant full registration where an independent assessment demonstrates the complete required outcome; otherwise a targeted evidence and training plan should apply.

- Do not use tenure alone as proof of competence.
- Do not force competent practitioners to repeat a full Certificate III where equivalent capability is reliably demonstrated.
- Do not weaken the outcome standard for practitioners approaching retirement; instead reduce unnecessary process and cost.

For workers approaching retirement, consider assisted applications, recognition of verified records and targeted cost relief. Age or intended retirement date should not automatically waive essential competence or extend authority. Compare the burden and safety effects of any special arrangements. [7]

Question 11 Pre-commencement measures

Implementation should begin with published scope guidance, practitioner-role maps, assessment specifications, transition eligibility tools and an independently tested operational pilot. Builders, carpenters, RTOs, assessors, unions, insurers and consumer representatives should test realistic cases before obligations commence.

Readiness criteria should cover clear scope, responsible decision makers, trained assessors, tested systems, forecast demand, accessible assistance, review mechanisms and funded compliance capacity. Publish who is responsible for each criterion and how readiness will be assessed. [6, slides 4 and 6]

- Publish examples distinguishing registered-builder, contractor and employee responsibilities.
- Test application and evidence forms with practitioners who did not design them.
- Train and calibrate assessors using common benchmark cases.
- Establish privacy, review, complaint, incident and reassessment processes before live assessment.
- Run a sustained education period before enforcement while acting immediately on deliberate or serious safety breaches.

Question 12 Preventing regulator and training bottlenecks

DTP and the BPC should forecast applications by region, qualification status and role, then stage intake accordingly. Assessment should identify gaps before a person is referred to training so scarce education capacity is not used for competencies already demonstrated. Before full commencement, operational testing should measure processing time, cost, regional access, assessor capacity, assessor agreement, moderation reversals and the effect of incomplete evidence.

DTP's slides estimate more than 20,000 carpenters in Victoria. Courtney Gleeson's reply refers the evidence question to the historical RIS. Its page 30 uses 2021 Census and then-regulator data to derive an unregistered cohort; that calculation is not a current residential-renovation count or an explanation of the slide estimate. Reconcile dates, occupational coverage, roles and registration categories before forecasting BPC, assessor or training demand. [2, p. 30; 6, slide 6; 9]

- Assess whether multiple assessment providers can operate within BPC decision-making, integrity and moderation arrangements; do not assume accreditation or delegated authority.
- Use digital lodgement with non-digital assistance and mobile or regional assessment options.
- Create pre-assessment self-checks and documentary screening.
- Publish service standards, queue data and escalation routes.

- Prevent low-integrity recognition of prior learning by auditing assessors and sampling evidence.

Question 13 Preventing workforce disruption

The transition design should provide adequate lead time, staged commencement and lawful continued work for timely applicants. The appropriate duration and eligibility rules should be modelled by cohort, qualification status, role and region. The Department should monitor departures, non-participation, subcontractor-to-employee shifts, regional shortages, costs and illegal work throughout transition.

The departmental email records concern about additional regulatory change and possible worker resistance. Test these concerns rather than assuming the size of any exit effect. Compare burdens on employees and subcontractors, include retirement profiles, and simplify process without weakening essential competence. [7]

- Avoid a single hard deadline for the entire cohort.
- Provide targeted financial support where transition cost is likely to drive otherwise competent practitioners from the industry.
- Coordinate with builders so tendering and site rostering reflect the commencement schedule.
- Use proportionate education-first enforcement for inadvertent early non-compliance, without tolerating deliberate evasion or unsafe work.

Class structure comparison

The initiative recommends a residential-only baseline. A work-and-risk-based residential scope is an option for testing against alignment to relevant existing domestic builder classes. The statutory mechanism remains open. DTP should compare the options using the same published criteria:

- coverage of material carpentry risks and avoidance of unintended omissions;
- clarity for practitioners, builders, consumers and enforcement officers;
- mobility within residential carpentry and clear boundaries when a practitioner moves into non-residential work;
- qualification, assessment, administration and compliance cost;
- fit with contracting, supervision, insurance and corporate-practitioner responsibilities; and
- capacity to add or refine specialist scopes without unnecessary duplication.
- compatibility with the BPC's operating model, transition capacity and the burden of further regulatory change.

The Department should publish the comparison and explain why the selected model is proportionate to the verified risk. This would allow stakeholders to assess both the scope coverage and the regulatory burden of the final proposal.

Interstate schemes provide useful comparisons. NSW recognises carpentry contractor licences and separate supervisor certificates for defined work. Queensland provides a carpentry licence class and contractor-type licences permitting direct contracts within licensed scope, with additional business and financial requirements. Compare their scope, role boundaries, burdens and available outcome data when designing a Victorian pathway. These published rules do not establish pilot results or prove reduced defects; their permissions and thresholds do not apply in Victoria. [18–19]

The structured meeting record reports a participant preference for simplicity and a general licence. Retain that broader option as contrary or alternative evidence; it does not establish government policy or displace this initiative's residential recommendation. Assess both scope and usability against risk, coverage and burden evidence. [5, DTPM-023 and 029]

Current evidence requested

A final Regulatory Impact Statement should use current evidence from DTP, the BPC and relevant training and workforce sources. Before the model is settled, the Department should publish or describe:

- the number of active carpenters by employment status, qualification pathway, region, age profile and principal work type;
- defect and complaint information attributed by work type, responsible role and cause, rather than sector totals alone;
- expected application volumes, assessment demand, processing capacity, regional access and service standards;
- current regulator, assessor, training, public-register, compliance and enforcement costs;
- expected effects on workforce participation, business structure, apprentice completion, illegal work and regional shortages; and
- the assumptions and evidence connecting entry regulation to efficiency, defect, dispute and consumer outcomes.

Where current evidence is unavailable, the final RIS should identify the uncertainty explicitly, use sensitivity ranges and commit to baseline and post-implementation measurement.

The departmental reply refers the evidence question to Chapter 2 of the historical RIS. That chapter identifies material concerns, while acknowledging data and attribution limits, including risk-selected inspections and dispute-counting effects. This supports examining the problem; it does not itself measure the incremental defect reduction from registration. Retain the request for current evidence and an evaluation against alternatives. The 6 October email records calls for stronger evidence and contrary views. [2, pp. 34–46; 7; 9]

Advanced residential capability and career progression

The consultation correctly focuses first on minimum competence for people physically performing regulated carpentry work. The Department should not assume that this minimum demonstrates every capability involved in complex alteration work in existing homes. Whether integrated renovation judgment constitutes a distinct capability gap requiring formal recognition remains an evidence question that should be tested rather than presumed. Testing must permit a negative, inconclusive or positive result.

Victoria should preserve a credible carpenter career pathway: apprenticeship and baseline trade competence, appropriate additional requirements for independent business operation, and optional assessed progression for defined residential work where need and public benefit are demonstrated. Do not require the full builder pathway for every narrower function if a proportionate lawful alternative can meet the same consumer outcome. Existing builder entry pathways remain directly available; advanced recognition must never become mandatory before builder registration. An endorsement, reform of DB-L Carpentry, optional RRC, a non-statutory credential or no additional mechanism remain options. Additional statutory contracting authority would require an authorised mechanism, not merely a voluntary credential.

Proposed RRC pilot and collaboration. I propose working with DTP and the BPC to design a bounded trial of additional residential capability, with defined scope, lawful permissions, oversight and evaluation before wider rollout. I offer to take a lead role in its development and delivery alongside a government-supported team, with appointments and resources determined by government and appropriately independent evaluation. Test work quality, consumer outcomes, costs, access and boundary decisions against a baseline and relevant alternatives, including existing pathways. Modify, narrow or discontinue the pathway if the evidence does not support it. The pilot would not itself grant statutory authority or commit government funding.

Capability level	Primary function	Evidence emphasis	Authority boundary
Apprentice	Supervised learning	Training contract and workplace evidence	Works only within apprenticeship arrangements
Residential carpenter baseline	Perform prescribed residential carpentry work in new and existing homes	Apprenticeship and Certificate III outcomes; verified existing-worker competence and targeted gap training	No broader contracting or builder authority by implication
Advanced residential capability	Integrated judgment in existing-home alteration and renovation	Validated evidence of integrated decisions, practical or scenario performance and boundary recognition	Optional modules and bounded authority under examination; no statutory permission or builder-entry prerequisite implied
Registered builder	Contracting, supervision and project responsibility within class	Technical, regulatory, business, financial and probity requirements	Existing statutory builder responsibilities

Evidence test for advanced residential capability

The proposition should be confirmed, narrowed or rejected using evidence from renovation-specific defects and complaints; work requiring integrated judgment across multiple carpentry activities; concealed-condition and progressive-discovery decisions; boundary, escalation and specialist-handoff performance; comparative practitioner assessments; assessor agreement and moderation; consumer and builder understanding of current scopes; interaction with DB-L Carpentry; and evidence of measurable public benefit.

No single indicator should determine the result. The analysis should also test whether existing registration, builder classes, guidance or non-statutory recognition already address the identified problem.

Practitioner cases can illustrate concealed-condition decisions, progressive discovery, verification and handoffs. They do not establish statewide prevalence, independent carpenter attribution or the absence of those outcomes from formal training. Recruitment of interested practitioners also creates selection bias: positive experience or self-selected participation cannot establish that the capability is distinct across the workforce. Test contrary cases, existing-pathway performance and negative or inconclusive results without changing governed confidence values.

Assessment architecture

Separate baseline regulatory verification from research into any residual advanced capability. Baseline requirements should align with the BPC's proportionate verification approach. The BPC describes reduced documentation for lower-risk categories and replacement of interviews with exams, starting with DB-U. That publication does not establish the exact future carpenter assessment specification. Do not prescribe mandatory interviews or a uniform practical assessment for every carpenter without a scope-specific justification. [6, slide 4; 8]

- Completed apprenticeship and Certificate III outcomes normally establish future entrants' baseline technical competence; justify additional checks by a specific regulatory purpose. For existing workers,

verify equivalent competence with work evidence, references and practical assessment where needed, then address identified gaps.

- Verified work history showing the work actually performed and the degree of responsibility exercised.
- Practical demonstration or structured scenarios where the risk of the work warrants it.
- Technical testing linked directly to the authorised scope and applicable mandatory standards.
- Referee verification that corroborates selected claims without transferring the assessment decision to the referee.
- Independent scoring, moderation, reasons, review rights and controlled reassessment.
- Critical-failure rules for unsafe action, fabrication, concealment, material authority overreach and failure to stop or refer when a clear boundary is reached.

The evidence methods above are options selected for the scope, risk and applicant evidence, not a cumulative test required of every worker. Any advanced-capability scenarios or interviews remain research methods until validated and accepted for a defined regulatory purpose.

The Advanced Residential Carpentry Assessment Standard and pilot instrument pack developed by Carpenters for Housing Reform Victoria are working materials, not validated regulatory instruments. They may provide a controlled way to test assessment usability and boundary judgment, but no claim of external endorsement or operational validation is made.

Evidence issues in the 2024 impact analysis

Historical reference only - not current policy or a current forecast. The 2024 draft impact analysis is useful historical material, but the Department states that it does not represent current policy and has not been updated for the reformed regulatory system. Any new RIS should retest its causal and cost assumptions.

Issue	Observed position	Recommended treatment
Benefit sensitivity	The historical analysis reports a positive result for Option 1 under its central assumptions, with an NPV of approximately \$481 million and a BCR of 2.20. Its sensitivity summary reports an NPV of approximately negative \$139 million and a BCR of 0.65 where efficiency benefits are limited to 0.25 per cent and defects and disputes do not decrease.	Publish low, central and high cases and identify the evidence supporting the assumed causal effect of registration. The cited historical results appear in the 2024 draft RIS, Table 0.10 on pages 106–107 and section 4.6.4 on page 118; they are not current policy forecasts.
Defect attribution	Sector-level defect data can include design, product, supervision, coordination and other trade causes.	Attribute defects by work type, responsible role and cause before claiming benefits from carpenter entry controls.
Scope omissions	The historical preferred option focused on framing, cladding, doors and windows, plus specialist formwork and falsework.	Test stairs, passive-fire carpentry, temporary works and cross-trade interfaces against current risk evidence.

Issue	Observed position	Recommended treatment
Workforce estimates	The historical analysis used point-in-time workforce and registration data.	Refresh workforce size, qualification, business structure, region and retirement-profile data.
Administrative cost	A large new cohort will require assessment, registration, public-register, compliance and enforcement capacity.	Model current BPC systems, staged intake and the cost of credible ongoing enforcement rather than entry processing alone.
Behavioural response	Registration may cause exit, avoidance, role changes or illegal work.	Monitor actual response and include targeted support and proportionate early enforcement.

Anticipated concerns and safeguards

Registration may increase assessment, administration and compliance costs without producing a corresponding improvement in quality. It may also contribute to workforce exit, reduced flexibility, duplicated builder responsibilities, avoidance or illegal work, assessment bottlenecks and inconsistent recognition of prior learning. Entry regulation will not by itself address defects caused by design, products, supervision, sequencing or commercial pressure.

Staging and process relief can reduce disruption, but they do not answer whether a restriction is justified. Compare less burdensome controls and narrow, revise or do not introduce additional restrictions where incremental benefit is not established. Where a scheme is justified, use current cost and workforce modelling, lawful continuity, clear role boundaries, independent moderation, regional access and published evaluation. Set feasible review triggers and responsible bodies before commencement; registration numbers alone do not demonstrate success.

Implementation safeguards

- No automatic assumption that registered status authorises consumer contracting, building-permit responsibility or work outside the prescribed class.
- No dilution of registered-builder responsibility for overall project coordination and supervision.
- No automatic grandfathering based solely on years worked.
- No full-qualification repetition for existing workers where equivalent competence is reliably demonstrated.
- No averaging away of a material safety, honesty or authority-boundary failure.
- No public representation that a pilot or voluntary assessment grants statutory authority.
- No expansion of restricted work solely to create occupational status; restriction must respond to verified risk and public benefit.

Evaluation should use a published baseline, attribution rules, methods, data limitations and reporting intervals. It should include appropriately independent evaluation or oversight so incomplete data and self-reporting do not produce unjustified conclusions.

Evaluation should also measure applicant time and cost, transitional backlog, regional access and incremental benefit relative to alternatives. Retain selection, attribution and incomplete-data limitations. Review scope, conditions or implementation where outcomes or burdens depart materially from the model, using feasible triggers and assigned responsibility.

Proposed measures of success

Outcome	Example measures
Building quality	Attributed defect rate and severity; rectification orders; recurrence by work type; concealed-work failures
Accountability	Practitioner traceability; complaint resolution; disciplinary timeliness; compliance after education or enforcement
Skills	Apprenticeship completion; recognition outcomes; gap-training completion; reassessment success
Workforce	Active practitioners; exits; regional shortages; processing delay; cost and time burden; illegal-work indicators
Consumer confidence	Understanding of scope; ability to verify status; complaints about misleading authority; survey confidence
System performance	Application service standards; assessor agreement; moderation reversals; appeals; audit findings

Material offered for further discussion

Carpenters for Housing Reform Victoria can provide the following working material for policy discussion, subject to its stated limitations. DB-L Carpentry Gap Analysis v0.2 provides preliminary scope and mechanism mapping for discussion; it is not presented as final legal analysis:

These are materials available for discussion, not a list of attachments supplied with this draft. External distribution of sensitive assessment content requires separate clearance; none of the instruments is presented as a validated regulatory assessment.

- Victorian Carpentry Capability Progression Model v0.1.
- DB-L Carpentry Gap Analysis v0.2.
- Trades Registration Consultation Evidence Brief v0.1.
- Advanced Residential Carpentry Assessment Standard v0.1.
- ARC Pilot Assessment Instrument Pack v0.1.
- Scope escalation decision states: PROCEED, PROCEED WITH CONTROL, INVESTIGATE, REFER, ESCALATE and STOP.

These working materials remain capability-first and adaptable to different regulatory mechanisms. This submission proposes RRC as a candidate for a bounded pilot, without predetermining the eventual statutory vehicle, criticising current DB-L practitioners or claiming government or regulator endorsement.

Conclusion

Victoria has a credible opportunity to improve accountability and occupational clarity while preserving workforce capability. This initiative recommends a residential-only carpenter baseline, with proportionate work-and-risk requirements, technical competence separated from contracting authority, reliable recognition of existing competence and clear builder and specialist boundaries. Advanced residential capability remains a separate progression question. Retain alternatives where evidence shows better coverage, enforceability or transition outcomes.

I support baseline residential carpenter registration in principle, with government still needing to justify its scope, cost, assessment and transition arrangements. I offer practical collaboration to develop and evaluate a bounded RRC pilot for additional residential capability. Define its function, scope, assessment, lawful authority and controls before wider rollout. Retain alternative mechanisms and existing builder pathways; change or discontinue the additional pathway if the evidence does not support it.

References

1. Department of Transport and Planning, Implementing carpentry registration and licensing, Consultation Paper, September 2026.
2. Department of Transport and Planning, Regulatory Impact Statement Building Amendment Carpentry Work Regulations 2024, historical draft published for reference in September 2026.
3. Engage Victoria, Registration and licensing of carpenters, consultation open 14 September to 11 October 2026.
4. Australian Building Codes Board, National Registration Framework.

Project working documents are listed under Material offered for further discussion.

5. Carpenters for Housing Reform Victoria, DTP Carpentry Consultation Meeting Record, 29 September 2026, v0.1, docs/evidence/dtp-carpentry-consultation-meeting-record-2026-09-29-v0.1.md. Partial transcript approximately 00:28–10:55; structured record and summary separately classified. [5]
6. Department of Transport and Planning, Implementing trades registration & licensing, seven-slide consultation presentation supplied as Trades Registration - Slidedeck.pdf and circulated with the 6 October email. Slides 2–6 cited by number. No visible publication date. [6]
7. Building Policy and Reform, Department of Transport and Planning, email dated 6 October 2026, 1:13 pm, Thank you for attending the trades registration and licensing consultation session, building.policy@transport.vic.gov.au. Departmental synthesis supplied as five screenshots; not a transcript or final policy decision. [7]
8. Building and Plumbing Commission, Licensing and registration reforms, accessed 7 October 2026, <https://www.bpc.vic.gov.au/resource-hub/industry-updates/licensing-and-registration-reforms>. General operating-model guidance; not a future carpenter assessment specification. [8]
9. Courtney Gleeson, Communications and Engagement Manager – Building, Department of Transport and Planning, reply to Dan Sonsie's email of 7 October 2026, 9:44 pm; reply text supplied by Dan on 8 October 2026. Incoming date not supplied. Refers to historical RIS sections 1.3, 1.3.2, 3.3.4, 3.3.4.1 and Chapter 2; continuing-discussion contact pending. [9]
10. Domestic Building Contracts Act 1995, authorised version 094 incorporating amendments as at 1 July 2026, sections 3 and 29; checked 8 October 2026. <https://www.legislation.vic.gov.au/in-force/acts/domestic-building-contracts-act-1995/094> [10]
11. Domestic Building Contracts Regulations 2017, authorised version 004, regulation 6; checked 8 October 2026. <https://www.legislation.vic.gov.au/in-force/statutory-rules/domestic-building-contracts-regulations-2017/004> [11]
12. Department of Transport and Planning, Notice of Preparation of Regulatory Impact Statement, Proposed Domestic Building Contracts Amendment Regulations 2026, 18 August 2026. Separate contract-reform process; the proposed \$20,000 threshold and reported timing are attributed to departmental correspondence [9], not treated as an operative change. <https://www.vic.gov.au/notice-preparation-regulatory-impact-statement-24> [12]
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14. WoodSolutions, Domestic Timber Deck Design, accessed 10 October 2026. Industry design guidance on dimensions, stress grades, spans, connections and exposure-appropriate durability and treatment;

not project-specific approval. <https://www.woodsolutions.com.au/publications/domestic-timber-deck-design> [14]

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16. DLI Training, Certificate III in Carpentry, and National Skills, CPC30220 Certificate III in Carpentry, provider pages accessed 10 October 2026. Approximately three-month RPL offers are distinguished from initial trade training; no provider misconduct or individual assessment failure is inferred. These pages describe CPC30220 and do not establish the current qualification-transition or future licensing rules. <https://www.dlitraining.edu.au/certificate-iii-in-carpentry/> and <https://lms.nationalskills.com.au/qualifications/cpc30220> [16]
17. Building and Plumbing Commission, Arrange Home Warranty for a project and Domestic Building Insurance and Home Warranty, checked 10 October 2026. Current project insurance guidance, separate from the major domestic building contract threshold and future carpenter-scheme settings. <https://www.bpc.vic.gov.au/builders/builders-insurance/arrange-home-warranty-for-a-project> and <https://www.bpc.vic.gov.au/home-owners/insurance-for-domestic-building-work/domestic-building-insurance-and-home-warranty> [17]
18. NSW Government, Carpentry work, checked 10 October 2026. Defined carpentry scope and contractor / supervisor licence types; interstate comparison, not Victorian authority or pilot evaluation. <https://www.nsw.gov.au/business-and-economy/licences-and-credentials/building-and-trade-licences-and-registrations/carpentry-work> [18]
19. Queensland Building and Construction Commission, Carpentry and Which licence type you need, checked 10 October 2026. Defined class, direct-contracting licence type and role requirements; interstate comparison, not evidence of causal defect reduction. <https://qbcc.qld.gov.au/licences/apply-licence/available-licences/other-trade/carpentry> and <https://www.qbcc.qld.gov.au/licences/start-your-career/which-licence-type-you-need> [19]
20. Victorian Budget 2026/27, Making life more affordable, checked 10 October 2026. \$16 million for implementing registration and licensing requirements; no allocation or commitment to this RRC proposal established. <https://www.2026.budget.vic.gov.au/making-life-more-affordable> [20]

Document control

Field	Value
Version	0.4 Review 7
Status	Submission candidate awaiting Dan's final approval; not submitted
Author	Carpenters for Housing Reform Victoria
Evidence custodian	Dan Sonsie
Prepared	10 October 2026; evolved from unchanged v0.3 dated 15 September 2026
Submission deadline	11 October 2026
External endorsement	None claimed
Next gate	D01, D02 and D03 retained. Future scheme questions remain unresolved. Review 7 is prepared for Dan's final approval before submission or publication.
Drafting authority	Dan authorised the interview changes, attribution and pilot direction on 10 October 2026. Final submission, publication and merge approval remain outstanding.
Scope decision	Dan approved a residential-only baseline on 7 October 2026. Government adoption is not claimed; specialist, mixed-use and statutory boundaries require review.
Role decision	Dan approved common technical competence with separate role requirements on 7 October 2026. No new consumer-contracting or builder authority implied; statutory terminology remains subject to review.
Entry decision	Dan approved future entrant apprenticeship plus Certificate III, with verified existing-worker equivalence and targeted gap training, on 8 October 2026. Government adoption is not claimed.
Departmental reply	Reply supplied 8 October 2026. Historical RIS status retained; \$20,000 contract threshold remains proposed; contact for capability and wet-area discussion pending.